

Important Child-Protection Terms

Report: An allegation to a state CPS hotline or intake channel typically by any public member who suspects child abuse or neglect happening to the child.

Investigation: The official CPS procedure that follows the acceptance of a report and is used to determine if abuse or neglect has occurred, which typically involves contact with the child, the family and other sources.

Substantiation: A finding following investigation that the evidence meets the state's legal criteria for finding abuse or neglect, with different states using different criteria and terminology, including "substantiated," "founded," "indicated," or similar terms.

Removal: The legal process of removing a child from the home, usually by court order or in an emergency, and placing the child in foster care or another placement due to safety concerns.

Reasonable Efforts: The legal requirement, established under federal law, that a child welfare agency make efforts to prevent a child's removal from the home and, where removal occurs, to work toward reunification before pursuing another permanency option.

Reunification: The process of safely returning a child to their parent or legal guardian after a period of removal or out-of-home placement, generally the preferred permanency outcome under federal and state law.

Permanency: A long-term, legally stable living arrangement for a child in foster care, achieved through reunification, adoption, guardianship, or another permanent placement, and required to be planned for within statutory timelines such as those set by the Adoption and Safe Families Act.

Termination of Parental Rights (TPR): The legal, court-ordered end of the parent-child relationship, which permanently removes a parent's rights and responsibilities toward the child and is a required step before a child can be freed for adoption.

Kinship Care: Placement of a child with a relative or another adult with an established relationship to the child, rather than a non-relative foster home, given legal preference in most states to preserve family connections and improve placement stability.

Congregate Care: Group or residential out-of-home placement, such as a group home or residential treatment facility, generally used only when a family-based foster placement is not appropriate, and increasingly restricted under federal law in favor of family-based settings.

Extended Foster Care: A state option, authorized under federal law, allowing youth who were in foster care before their 18th birthday to remain in care past age 18, typically until age 21, to support their transition to adulthood.

Aging Out: When a youth exits the foster care system upon reaching the age of majority, or the extended foster care age limit, without achieving permanency through reunification, adoption, or

guardianship.

Title IV-E: The section of the federal Social Security Act that provides the primary federal funding stream for foster care maintenance payments, adoption assistance, guardianship assistance, and related administrative and training costs.

Prevention Services: Services intended to keep children safely in their own homes and avoid the need for foster care placement, funded in part through the federal Title IV-E prevention option established by the Family First Prevention Services Act.